

Student Tutorial 3: Sharing and Documenting Models

Hands-on activity: writing basic documentation for a model

What you will learn

In this exercise, you will learn how to document a model so that other people can understand what it is for, how it was created or used, how it was evaluated, what it should not be used for, and what its limitations are.

Why model documentation matters

A model is not only a file. If someone receives only model weights, a model name, or a script, they may not know:

- what the model does
- what data it was trained on or built from
- which version it is
- how well it performs
- what it should or should not be used for
- what limitations or risks it has
- what license or reuse conditions apply

Good documentation supports transparency, responsible reuse, reproducibility, and clearer interpretation.

Your task

Create a short model documentation file. You can imagine that you are sharing a statistical model, a machine learning classifier, a fine-tuned language model, an epidemiological model, or a model used for a research project.

Model documentation template

Model name

Version

Which version of the model is this?

Purpose

What is this model for?

Intended use

Who is expected to use it, and for what purpose?

Out-of-scope use

What should this model not be used for?

Training or source data

What data was used to train, build, or fit the model?

If the data cannot be shared, describe them briefly.

Evaluation

How was the model evaluated?

What metric or approach was used?

Limitations

Where might the model fail?

What should users be careful about?

License

What are the reuse conditions?

Remember that code, data, and model weights may have different licenses.

How to use

How can someone run or apply the model?

Plain-language explanation of key terms

- Training or source data: the data used to build, train, fit, or fine-tune the model.
- Evaluation: how the model was tested or assessed.
- Limitations: where the model may perform badly, be uncertain, or be inappropriate to use.
- Out-of-scope use: uses that the model was not designed or validated for.
- How to use: basic instructions for applying or running the model.

Reflection question

If someone found this model online, would they understand what it does, how it was assessed, where caution is needed, and what it should not be used for?